Datadog · Quick concepts

Interview revision sheet. Read it the evening before, then test yourself in Interview practice.

Basics

- SaaS observability: infrastructure, APM, logs, synthetics, RUM, security.
- Datadog Agent on hosts (DaemonSet in Kubernetes); integrations for common tech.
- Tags as key:value; unified service tagging: env, service and version.

Metrics and monitors

- Metric types: count, rate, gauge, histogram, distribution (accurate global percentiles).
- DogStatsD sends custom metrics; high-cardinality tags raise cost.
- Monitor types: metric, log, APM, synthetic, process, anomaly, outlier, forecast, composite.
- Notifications with @slack-channel or @email; downtimes mute during maintenance.
- Enable "no data" alerts for critical heartbeats.

APM and traces

- Service map, traces and spans, latency, errors and throughput per endpoint.
- Trace sampling and retention filters control volume.
- Inject trace IDs into logs to jump between traces and logs.
- Deployment tracking with the version tag compares releases.
- Continuous Profiler shows hot code paths.

Logs

- Pipelines with processors (Grok parser, remappers) parse logs.
- Facets make attributes searchable; search like service:web status:error.
- Indexes (searchable, retention) vs archives (cheap, in your storage, rehydrate when needed).
- Exclusion filters and metrics from logs cut cost.

Other features

- Synthetics: API and browser tests from many locations.
- RUM and Session Replay for real user experience.
- Watchdog (AI anomalies), SLOs, notebooks, Error Tracking, Cloud SIEM.
- Cluster Agent and Autodiscovery for Kubernetes.

Troubleshooting

- datadog-agent status shows checks, errors and connectivity.
- No APM data: check APM is enabled, the tracer library is installed and port 8126 is reachable.